DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Does the Soul Really See and Hear?

Daat Tevunot §80

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §80 (end)
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 7 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

The class began halfway down page 194 of the English, near the end of §80. The Rabbi reviewed the section so far:

- The body has primal desires; the soul comes from above. The purpose of life is for the soul to prevail and, in the end, to refine the body.
- The balance between soul and body in people determines how much light or concealment there is in the world. When souls prevail there is more hearah; when bodies prevail there is more hester.
- Soul and body are a microcosm of God's own ways: the soul reflects His illumination and the body His concealment.
- God is one; so too the soul has no parts, while the body has many organs, each with its own function.

The end of §80: what we mean when we say the soul sees

The Ramhal finishes the comparison. The body has many parts with separate, limited functions. The soul in its essence is one thing, and its ways are completely different from the body's. Since the soul is what enables the body to function, we say that the soul sees through the eyes and hears through the ears, and call it "seeing" and "hearing". But that is not really how the soul sees.

The body by itself is a piece of meat. What gives the eye the ability to see and the ear the ability to hear is the soul. So we say the soul sees and hears, just as we say God sees and hears. But we do not mean it literally. The soul's way of knowing is something the body cannot understand.

This, the Ramhal says, is exactly how we speak about God. We call Him compassionate, merciful and truthful because He acts in ways that we perceive as compassion and mercy. But He has no parts that are compassionate and parts that are merciful. When we speak of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, "we're talking about the way we understand HaKadosh Barukh Hu's actions. We are never talking about God itself." The Ramhal calls this "a great opening to understand things".

Questions: eyes, blindness and the soul

The group pressed the point in several ways.

"Do not stray after your eyes." If the soul gives the power of sight, is straying after the eyes the body or the soul? The Rabbi answered that the eyes belong to the body. The soul gives the body the ability to see; what the body does with its eyes is up to the person.

Is blindness a failure of the body or of the soul? In most cases today we can identify what is missing in the eye or the nerves, so it is a failure of the body: the soul has nothing to switch on. In theory a person could have perfectly working eyes and still not see, and in a case where we cannot find a cause, one might say it comes from the soul, though there may also be a physical cause we do not yet know. "You need both together."

Who commits the sin?

Mark asked: if the soul enables the body to act, is it the soul or the body that does wrong? The Rabbi said the soul allows the body to act, and the body is what pulls towards the wrong choice. The intellect is given to us to work out what is good and what is bad.

A participant suggested that consciousness must then belong to the body. The Rabbi disagreed: consciousness is part of the soul, our identity, the one making the decision. The group arrived at a picture he accepted: the soul is one side of the debate in your head, saying "don't do that", the body is the pull, and your consciousness, the meeting point where the choice is made, is who you end up being. "Those choices made is who you are."

So what is a person "with no conscience"? Not someone without a soul, but someone who never exercises his soul to control his body and lets the body run riot.

Physical gifts are the body's

Someone asked whether outstanding physical abilities, like a great boxer's, come from the soul. No, said the Rabbi: "That's the genetic lottery." Some people are clever and some not, some tall and some short, some strong and some weak. That is the diversity of human beings and their different roles, and it belongs to the body.

A participant recalled the film Chariots of Fire, about two runners at the 1920s Olympics, one of them a Christian missionary who said that when God made him He made him fast, and when he ran he felt God's pleasure. The Rabbi agreed that maximising the physical gifts God gave you is wonderful, and it can bring you to a spiritual experience, just as using the body for misvot does, like giving charity or dancing to make a bride and groom happy. "The body is a vehicle to get there." But the gift itself is still the body's.

The parallel to the sefirot

In the last minutes Mark asked what exactly the parallel is. The Rabbi summarised: God is not merciful and compassionate in the way we perceive it; He is all one. So too the soul does not see in the way we think; it gives life to the eyes. Mark suggested that the real parallel is the sefirot, which stand to God somewhat as the body stands to the soul. The Rabbi agreed that

the sefirot are not God but the means of His interaction with the world, and the class ended there.

Summary

- The end of §80: the soul is one and acts through the body's many organs, so we say it "sees" and "hears", though it does not see as the body does.
- In the same way we call God merciful and compassionate by how we perceive His actions, not because He has parts.
- The eyes belong to the body; the soul gives them life. Blindness is usually a failure of the body.
- The soul argues, the body pulls, and our consciousness, where the choice is made, is who we become.
- Physical talents belong to the body, but used well they can lead to spiritual experience.

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